

Product Roadmap Guide: What is it & How to Create One

A product roadmap is a shared source of truth that outlines the vision, direction, and progress of a product over time.



> By Bree Davies, Atlassian Product Manager

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Key Takeaways

- A product roadmap is a strategic plan that outlines the vision, direction, priorities, and progress of a product over time.
- Roadmaps align teams and stakeholders around short and long-term goals, linking daily work to business objectives.
- Effective roadmaps are clear and are regularly updated to reflect changing priorities.
- Create and maintain a product roadmap to communicate strategy, track progress, and drive stakeholder alignment.

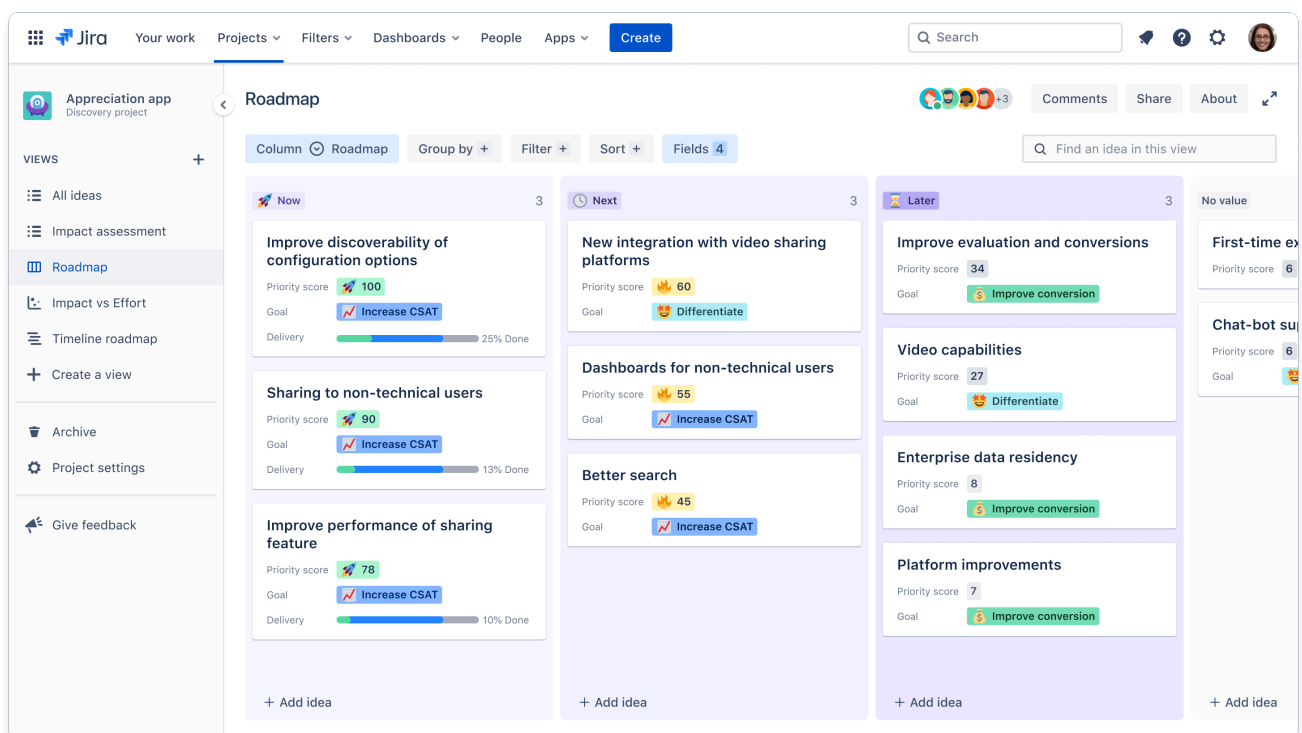
A product roadmap is essential to any [product strategy](#) because it communicates how short-term efforts match long-term business goals. Understanding the role of a roadmap—and how to create a great one—is key to keeping everyone on your team headed in the same direction.

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What is a product roadmap?

A product roadmap is a shared source of truth that outlines the vision, direction, priorities, and progress of a product over time. It's a plan of action that aligns the organization around short and long-term goals for the product or project, and how they will be achieved.

While it's common for the roadmap to show what you're building, it's just as important to show why. Items on the roadmap should be clearly linked to your product strategy and goals, and your roadmap should be responsive to changes in customer feedback and the competitive landscape.



Product owners use roadmaps to collaborate with their teams and build consensus on how a product will grow and shift over time. [Agile teams](#) refer back to the product roadmap to keep everyone on the same page about which product ideas have been prioritized and when, and to gain context for their everyday work and future direction.

Which teams use product roadmaps?

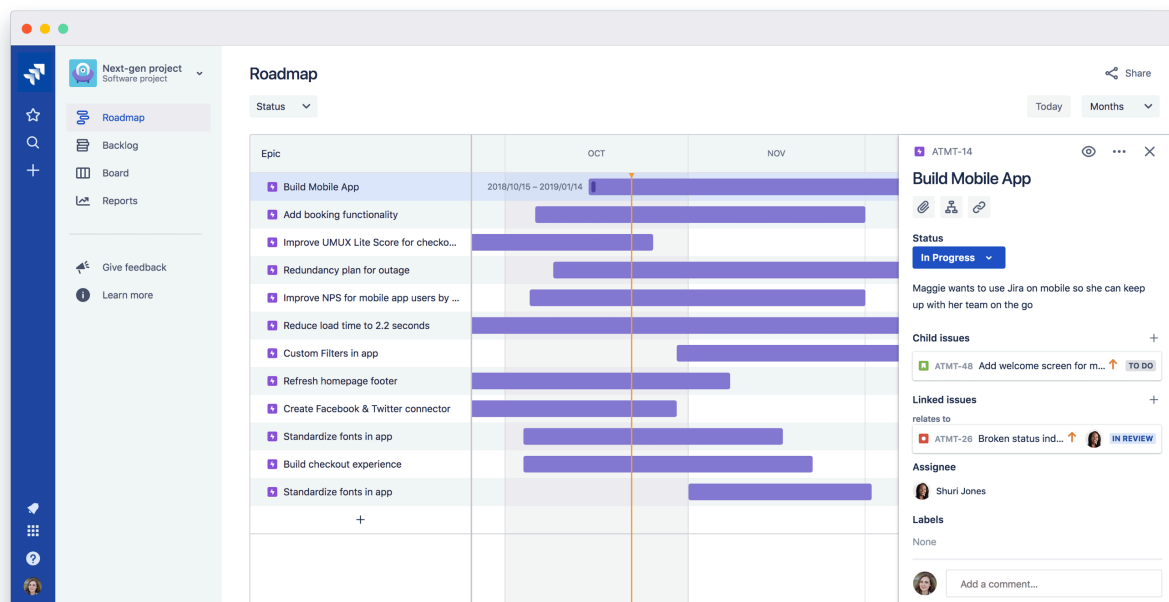
Roadmaps come in several different forms and serve a variety of audiences. Let's look at some product roadmap examples:

Internal roadmap for the development team

Development team roadmaps can be created in several ways, depending on how your team likes to work. Some common versions include the detail about the prioritized customer value to be delivered, target release dates and milestones.

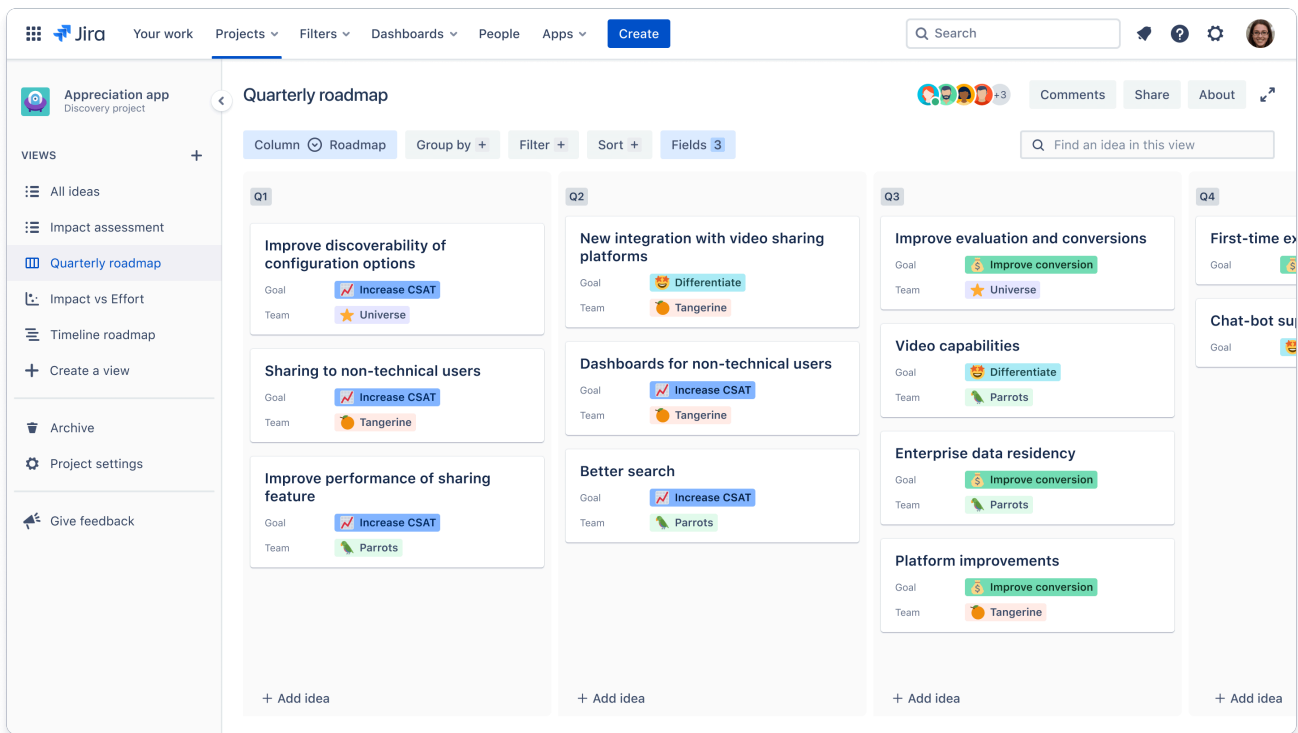
As a general rule, development teams should use a product roadmap to understand the product strategy, how it connects to goals, and why initiatives have been prioritized. For the actual development work, dev teams should create a separate delivery plan that maps back to the product roadmap.

Since many development teams use [Agile methodologies](#), these plans are often organized by sprints and show specific pieces of work and problem areas plotted on a timeline.



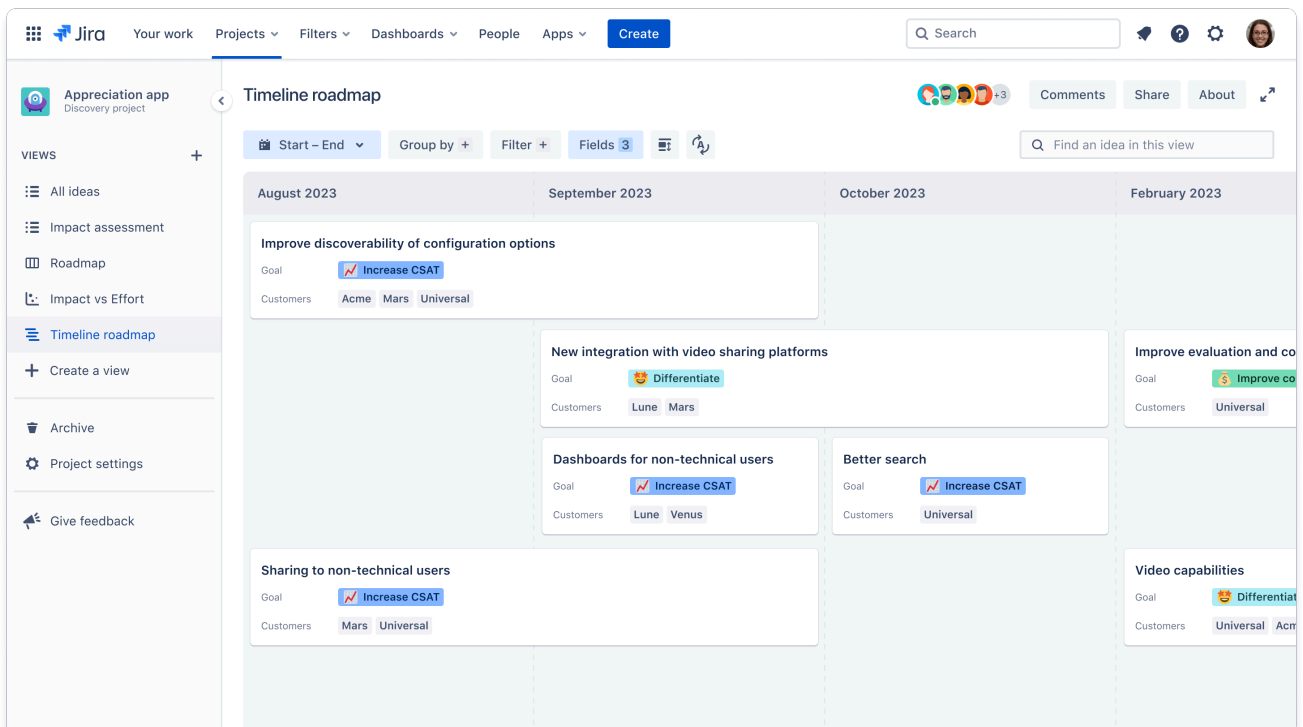
Internal roadmap for executives

Executive roadmaps emphasize how teams' work supports high-level company goals and metrics. They are often organized by month or by quarter to show progress over time toward these goals, and generally include less detail about detailed [product development](#) stories and tasks.



Internal roadmap for sales

Sales roadmaps focus on new features and customer benefits, and may even include key customers who are interested in these features in order to support sales conversations. An important note: avoid including hard dates in sales roadmaps to avoid tying internal teams to potentially unrealistic dates.



External roadmap

External roadmaps should excite customers about what's coming next. Make sure they are visually appealing and easy to read. They should provide a high-level, generalized view of new features and prioritized problem areas to get customers interested in the future direction of the product.

Who creates the product roadmap?

The product roadmap is typically created by [product managers](#) in collaboration with engineering, design, marketing, and other stakeholders. Product managers gather input from across the organization to ensure the roadmap reflects customer needs, technical feasibility, and business strategy. Effective roadmaps are the result of ongoing communication and alignment. For example, product managers might hold regular planning sessions with cross-functional teams to prioritize initiatives and adjust the roadmap as the [product strategy](#) evolves.

Why are product roadmaps important?

The biggest benefit of the product roadmap is the strategic vision it illustrates to all stakeholders. The roadmap ladders up to broader product and company goals with development efforts, which connects work across teams and aligns those teams around common goals to create great products.

- **For organizational leadership:** The roadmap provides updates on the status of planned features and improvements in a format that connects back to company goals and is easily understood.
- **For product owners and managers:** Roadmaps unify teams working on high impact product enhancements and allow them to communicate priorities and why they were prioritized effectively with adjacent teams.
- **For the developers themselves:** Roadmaps provide a better understanding of the “big picture,” which allows team members to focus on the most important tasks, avoid scope creep, and make fast, autonomous decisions.

How to create a product roadmap

To build a roadmap, [product owners](#) should evaluate ideas based on key criteria, such as market trajectories, customer insights and feedback, company goals, and effort constraints. Once these factors are understood, product teams can work together to start prioritizing initiatives on the roadmap.

The content of a roadmap will depend on its audience—a roadmap for the development team may cover only one product, while a roadmap for executives can cover multiple products. Depending on the size and structure of an organization, a single roadmap may span multiple teams working on the same product.

An external roadmap will often cover multiple products aligned with one point of emphasis or customer need.

The most important takeaway: create a roadmap that your audience can easily understand. Providing too much or too little detail on the roadmap can make it easy to gloss over, or worse, too intimidating to read.

A roadmap with just the right amount of detail and some visual appeal can earn the buy-in you need from key stakeholders. You can get started with a [free product roadmap template](#) to kickstart your process!

Free product roadmap template

Presenting the product roadmap

The product roadmap needs buy-in from two key groups: leadership and the agile development team. A [product roadmap presentation](#) is a great opportunity to demonstrate to key stakeholders that you understand the company's strategic objectives.

This also shows you know the needs of your customer and have a plan to meet them both. As you move through the project, make sure to link your delivery team's work back to the product roadmap for context and visibility into progress for your team and stakeholders.

A tried-and-true method: map out the ideas you're committing to on your product roadmap. Then break down those ideas into [epics](#), [requirements](#), and [user stories](#) on your delivery roadmap.

Often times, each initiative will have a corresponding epic that needs to be broken down into smaller tasks to complete. Establishing this hierarchy makes it easier for product and development teams to make decisions together, and understand how their work fits into the bigger picture.

When sharing roadmap progress asynchronously, a recorded walkthrough is more effective than a static slide deck. [Loom](#) lets product managers narrate changes on-screen during [product roadmap reviews](#), giving viewers context behind priority shifts without scheduling another meeting.

Using and updating the roadmap

Roadmapping doesn't end once you've reached your final state. The competitive landscape can shift. Customers' preferences may change. Planned features might be modified.

It's important to take any learnings or insights and feed them back into your team's discovery process. This ensures the product roadmap continues to reflect the status of current work as well as long-term goals.

The roadmap should be updated as often as necessary. This could be every week or fortnightly. Frequent updates help it remain an accurate source of truth. A roadmap is counter-productive if it isn't up to date.

Many of us have experienced this. You'll know if your roadmap needs more frequent updates when stakeholders start calling you for updates instead of consulting the

roadmap. These one-off requests show a lack of trust in your roadmap. They can also become a huge time drain.

On the other hand, you don't want to spend more time updating the roadmap than needed. The goal is to achieve alignment between stakeholders and your team. The roadmap is a product planning tool.

It helps you think through how to build great products that impact your customers and your business. If you're spending too much time updating the roadmap instead of executing, reconsider your update cadence.

Also, review how you gather inputs, feedback, and data from across the business to prioritize your initiatives.

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Best practices for the best roadmaps

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